Alefiya J Malubhoy – A0226616E

alefiya.m@u.nus.edu

GES1012: Pop Culture in Singapore

Dr John Solomon and Dr Iqbal Singh Sevea

14th April 2021

Censored History:

Sexual Deviance in 'In the Room'[1]

Introduction

The Singaporean government's strict censorship policies led to severely controlled film content for several decades in the post-independence era (S. W. M. Tan, 1998). Despite gaining classifications in 1991 that allowed more films to pass uncensored, Singapore's first proclaimed erotic film, Eric Khoo's *In the Room*, only surfaced in 2015 (Liew & Teo, 2016).

The film's six short stories weave together in an omnibus, paying tribute not only to various historical figures and events, but also to the film industry itself. Indeed, the very film is dedicated to the late Damien Sin, who wrote Khoo's first feature *Mee Pok Man*. He is also the inspiration behind the 70s musician and lyricist Damien in the short 'Listen,' who haunts the hotel room for years to come, watching the stories occur.

Khoo's filmmaking in the 90s has engaged in necessary self-censorship in order to be screened, notably for his famous 1997 work *12 Storeys* (Udhe & Udhe, 2000 cited in S. K. Tan et al., 2003). *In the Room*'s contrasting unrestrained narrative pays homage to all the unseen parts of Singaporean history that were deemed too socially unacceptable at the time to be publicly

[1] The essay, including all timestamps, refers to the version of the movie on Netflix as of 14th April 2021.

displayed. This essay posits that through *In the Room*, Eric Khoo uses the lens of sexual deviance to explore Singaporean history in an attempt to fill in the gaps created across decades of strict censorship.

Queer Narratives

Rights of homosexuals, especially gay men, and transgender people have long-since been a taboo topic in colonial and independent Singapore (Chen, 2013), and the positive portrayal of LGBT people was strictly banned prior to the 1991 changes in film classifications. Through the stories of 'Rubber' and 'Change', Khoo gives a fictional voice to the lost stories of queer communities in the 1940s and 1980s.

The first story's black-and-white film, quick transitions, and stable shots are all hallmarks of a typical 1940s movie (Salt, 1976) that transport the viewer back to the very day that 'Rubber' is set in – 15th February 1942, the day of the British surrender to Japanese forces (0:05:55 - 0:06:15). Rather than focusing on the historical significance of the day, Khoo chooses to narrate the more personal tale of separation of a British expat between his Chinese lover, that intertwines colonial discourse, imperialism and politics into a then-taboo interracial, queer relationship, punctuated by the tender parting of the two men (0:10:40).

'Change', on the other hand, deals with the topic of gender. Based on the bold prints of Room 27's mise-en-scene, this story is presumably set in the 1980s and traces the night before a transgender Thai woman gets gender-reaffirming surgery. It serves to highlight the curious conundrum of Singaporean policing, as the husband exclaims, "This country is crazy! Men aren't allowed to have long hair, but the president can make artificial vaginas?" (0:35:05). The story's reference tributes former President Benjamin Sheares and accoladed researcher Dr. Shan

Ratnam, whose contributions to the field of sex-change surgery are often overlooked in favour of their more conventional achievements (Yue, 2017). The story's elements of transgender women and hotels may also be a subtle nod to *Bugis Street* (1995), the film that boosted local Singaporean productions to the forefront of the government policies.

Female Sexuality

Through 'Pussy', 'Search', and 'First Time', Khoo represents the development and dubious liberation of female sexuality. 'Pussy,' set in the 1950s' signature vibrant technicolour tones, is brimming with slapstick, sexual humour brought out by the now-dynamic camera shots. The short outlines the story of Rose Chan, a cabaret dancer, stripper and sex-worker whose scandalous acts often led her to clash with the law (Ong, 2009). She juxtaposes the image of the conservative wife that the government was advocating – instead, she fully embodies both the physical and sexual prowess of a woman. The prowess of Chan's performances is transposed onto film, as she stands in her (aptly-tailored for the 50s) lingerie in front of a fully-clothed man, and says, "You and I are the only ones in power here." (0:17:38).

However, women's sexual freedom soon becomes its own burden to them. In 'Search', a Japanese housewife's affair with her Singaporean lover causes her much strife when she must choose between following her heart's true desire and the traditional duty of a wife, symbolized by her jewellery (0:57:29). Though she ultimately must reject him, Mariko's story depicts the changing role of women who fight against orthodox stereotypes and polices (Pyle, 1997).

'First Time' cements this theme – the commercialization of femininity has left a young Korean girl feeling "broken" for not experiencing the pleasure of sex. Exacerbated through the flux of migrant Koreans in the 1990s (Teo & Sing, 2015), the short seems to represent the

parallel commercialization of Singapore itself as a tourist destination. “No art, no history. Sterile, like a hospital. With so many strict rules,” the character says, describing the reason she vacationed to Singapore to forget her heartache (1:01:38 – 1:01:51).

Conclusion

Through *In the Room*, Eric Khoo imagines a series of films that may have had a place in cinemas before the 2000s had the censorship laws in Singapore not confined auteurs. He forgoes grand narratives, instead using intimacy to celebrate the rebels who paved the way for such stories to be performed. Khoo depicts salacious and deviant behaviour in order to not only capture and but also pay homage to those aspects of Singaporean history that were shunned by official policy in the name of propriety.

References

Chen, J. (2013). Singapore's Culture War over Section 377A: Through the Lens of Public Choice and Multilingual Research. *Law and Social Inquiry*, *38*(1), 106–137. https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1747-4469.2012.01297.x

Liew, K. K., & Teo, S. (2016). *Singapore Cinema: New Perspectives*. Taylor and Francis.

Ong, C. (2009). Rose Chan. In *Singapore Infopedia*.

Pyle, J. L. (1997). Women, the Family, and Economic Restructuring: the Singapore Model? *Review of Social Economy*, *55*(2), 215–223.

Salt, B. (1976). Film Style and Technology in the Forties. *Film Quarterly*, *31*(1), 46–57. https://doi.org/10.2307/1211681

Tan, S. K., Lee, H. H. M., & Aw, A. (2003). Contemporary Singapore Filmmaking: history, policies and Eric Khoo. *Jump Cut: A Review of Contemporary Media*, *46*. http://www.ejumpcut.org/archive/jc46.2003/12storeys/text.html

Tan, S. W. M. (1998). *Bright lights, small city: New beginnings of the Singapore film industry* [Edith Cowan University]. https://ro.ecu.edu.au/theses_hons/459

Teo, D., & Sing, J. (2015). @SGIFF2015: Production Talk with Eric Khoo on "In The Room." *SINdie*. https://www.sindie.sg/2015/11/sgiff2015-production-talk-with-eric.html

Yue, A. (2017). *Trans-Singapore: some notes towards queer Asia as method, Inter-Asia Cultural Studies*. *18*(1), 10–24. https://doi.org/10.1080/14649373.2017.1273911